# 5

# GOING NUCLEAR

Now that he knew what had to be done, Khrushchev was unstoppable. On May 21, 1962, the day after his return to Moscow from Bulgaria, Khrushchev called a meeting of the Defense Council, which consisted of members of the party and government leadership. Also present was the new chief of the Soviet Strategic Rocket Forces, Marshal Sergei Biriuzov.

Khrushchev began a report on his trip and then turned to Cuba. “I said that it would be foolish to expect the inevitable second invasion to be as badly planned and as badly executed as the first,” recalled Khrushchev. “I warned that Fidel would be crushed if another invasion were launched against Cuba and said that we were the only ones who could prevent such a disaster from occurring.” He then presented his case for placing medium- and intermediate-range ballistic missiles on Cuban soil: “In addition to protecting Cuba, our missiles would equalize what the West likes to call the ‘balance of power,’ ” recalled Khrushchev years later.[1]